

Briefing Sheet for Wandsworth/Kingston/Richmond SACREs

Purpose of this briefing to SACRES

This briefing sheet is to advise SACRES on the new Relationships, Sex and Health Education (RSHE) mandatory guidance issued by the Department for Education (DfE) for use in schools from September 2026.

Wandsworth, Richmond and Kingston Local Authorities are working together to update their own guidance to schools on RHSE. In 2019 Wandsworth produced a document called Getting to Grips with the new RSHE guidance and Richmond and Kingston Achieving for Children produced a joint statement of support for schools. For the 2026 DfE update the three boroughs will be producing a single joint document of briefing and support for schools on RSHE for implementation from September 2026. The working title of this document is 'Getting to Grips 2', although a more appropriate title will be found before final publication.

This briefing sheet for SACRES, and a glimpse at the first draft of the joint document being prepared by Wandsworth, Richmond and Kingston, are to keep SACRES up to date with the new DfE guidance and how schools will have to comply with it.

After SACRES have read this briefing, the draft Local Authority document along with the new DfE mandatory guidance on RSHE, the authors of the joint document would be happy to receive any feedback from SACRES, should they choose to make it.

Context of RSHE

Schools have long been tasked to provide not just academic and creative education for children and young people, but also to educate them to be equipped as well as possible with knowledge and skills that will help keep them safe and healthy as they take their place in the world today.

In order to do this, schools have to provide learning opportunities and discuss topics that include how their bodies work and reproduce, possible threats and harms that can come to them from unhealthy activities such as alcohol and drugs, and the nature of human relationships including sexual ones. These lessons are known as RSHE and schools usually provide at least one dedicated lesson on them each week for students.

OFSTED are always keen to look during their inspections at how well schools prepare children for adult life with RSHE lessons, and they often comment directly upon it in their reports.

Why is this an issue for SACRES?

There is an overlap between some RSHE topics and those that are covered in Religious Studies lessons, both at Primary and Secondary level, as aspects of them may be regarded as moral or ethical issues. This extends to examination level (both GCSE and A level), as these often explore faith perspectives on issues such as sex and sexuality, drugs, women's rights etc and have had these at the core of the curriculum for a long time. It is important that SACRES are aware of the new DfE guidance, as part of their role regarding Religious Studies in schools.

Content and Nature of RSHE lessons.

From time to time the DfE issues new guidance for schools in these areas which updates the topics taught to reflect the current picture in the world today - for example, the growth in the place of electronic technologies and the internet in young people's lives has given rise to dangers and experiences that just did not exist in the past, and it is important that schools

include these topics and keep their curricula as up to date as necessary to make sure they stay appropriate and relevant. Children and young people should not only learn facts in these lessons, they should also be given time and activities to be able to reflect on the topics to help form their own healthy responses to the possible harms that are sadly present in the world today.

By their nature, RSHE lessons teach about personal and adult topics which some parents may have concerns about their children learning. Parents may feel ill-equipped to discuss these topics with their own children and fear that schools will in some way expose children to harm rather than help them develop healthy responses. Should parents have these fears, they should discuss them with schools who under the new guidance are able to show parents the kind of resources and lessons to help dispel any such concerns.

Similarly, some parents may be concerned that their own faith may have teachings in some of these topics, and may be concerned that teaching in school might go against their beliefs. Again, should parents have these fears they should discuss them directly with the school to find out what is actually being taught, what resources are being used and how the lessons are structured, because it is most likely that their fears are unfounded. It is clear in the DfE guidance that schools should teach all these topics at the appropriate age and stage of learning for their children and young people, and indeed this has long been the case.

Parents and faith groups have confidence that schools tailor their lessons in Maths, English, Science and other subjects appropriately to the age and stage of learning of the children in their classes, and be inclusive in nature reflecting different views where appropriate, and RSHE is no different in these regards.

New DfE Update.

Relationships, Sex Education and Health Education (RSHE) guidelines were last updated significantly in 2019, and the DfE have just issued a new update to this guidance for schools to be implemented in September 2026. This update can be found by clicking this link below.

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/68b8499e11b4ded2da19fd92/Relationships_education_relationships_and_sex_education_and_health_education_-_statutory_guidance.pdf

What the new guidance covers

Sections 1 and 2 in the draft joint document details what the new guidance covers

Faith Responses.

Faiths in Britain who sponsor schools usually produce their own curricula which reflect their own teachings whilst fulfilling the requirements of the DfE guidance and to date this has been working well. In the joint guidance to schools document you will find links to some of these resources in Section 6, and by the time the document is finally produced, more resources will have been developed by groups and will be included in this section. Should any member of SACRE be aware of any updated school resources for their own particular faith other than those shown, the authors of the joint document would be happy to receive signposting to them.

SACREs role in the new joint document.

In sending the new joint document to SACREs whilst still in early draft form, Wandsworth, Richmond and Kingston are taking a step to keep SACREs informed of the existence of the new DfE guidance in order to reassure them as to what schools are being asked to do from Sept

2026, that the DfE guidance is both clear and mandatory on the topics it proscribes, and that schools are, as ever, working to continue to prepare children and young people to take a safe, healthy and happy place in the world.

With SACREs permission, the document would like to reflect that it has been shared with members in its draft form with each of the Local Authority SACREs.

Cath Brookes and Kaye Seamer – joint authors of the joint document.